The Good Times are Killing Me

By Lynda Barry

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

EDNA: **(Pg 9)** My name is Edna Arkins. Do you ever wonder what is music? Who invented it and what for and all that? And why just hearing a certain song can make a whole entire time of your life suddenly just rise up and stick in your brain? There was a lot of music on my street. The best time you could hear it was after dinner in the summer when the radios were on and the front doors were open and you hear all the people on their porches **(Pg 11)** *(Sings a few lines from "UnCloudy Day")*

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 2: *12-year old Bonna Willis likes to give "beatings" to those who deserve it.*
ACTRESS 1: *And Edna Arkins might just be someone who deserves it. But that's before and after.*
ACTRESS 2: *Before and after their friendship, that is – a friendship isn't exactly allowed because*
ACTRESS 1: *Bonna is black and*
ACTRESS 2: *Edna is white.*
ACTRESS 1: *And while things might be changing in Seattle in the late 1960's,*
ACTRESS 2: *it hasn't changed enough for these two girls to be friends forever.*
TOGETHER: *The Good Times are Killing Me by Lynda Barry*

EDNA: **(Pg 14)** I remember the exact first time I ever saw Bonna Willis. I stood up and shouted "Excuse me girl!" but she didn't answer me, so I figured either she was hard of hearing or boy was she ever stuck up.

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BONNA: I heard you.

MRS. WILLIS: Bonna Willia! You better get back over here! Don't let me have to tell you twice!

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EDNA: **(Pg 15)** Sings: The hills are alive, with the sound of music . . . *(to audience)* The first best movie I ever saw and the first best music I ever heard. All I ever wanted to be in life was the star of that show. Someone who sang like a record and ran and twirled in the mountains. Someone so perfect that even the nuns couldn't understand her. *(Notices Bonna again)* **(Pg 30)** The first time I ever saw Bonna Willis close up – the main thing I noticed about her was that for earrings she had little pieces of broom straws with the ends burnt off stuck through her ears. I asked her way later what was the first thing she noticed about me.

BONNA: *(almost flirtatiously)* How much you looked like the what-me-worry guy off of Mad Magazine. I'm not saying it to be cold. You can't control the first thing you notice about somebody. **(Pg 34-36)** *(To a boy off stage)* Mess with my brother again and I'll knock you upside your nappy little head *(Bonna stomps her foot like she is going to run after him)*

EDNA: Back then, all I knew about Bonna Willis was that I had to watch out for her.

BONNA: Everybody did. *(to boy off stage)* Laugh all you want to, fool *(She runs after him)*

EDNA: She would get after you, swearing to beat the a**es off everyone in our neighborhood on a rotating basis. And it wasn't just all talk and no action either.

EARL: *(looks on stage to see that Bonna is gone, then enters with Bonita)*

BONITA: Uh huh. Then where she at?

EARL: Like I told you. She run home crying. She come out here all trying to mess with me like she really something. I had to just laugh in her face. I say "Listen girl.

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You just a squirrel in my world!" I do my foot just like this . . . *(Earl stomps his foot imitating Bonna)* You should have seen her running. *(Sees Edna)* Ain't that right?

EDNA: OOOOOOooooo! Bonna can beat you're a** any day! *(Edna takes off running)*

EARL: Don't you let me catch you on this street alone!

BONITA: *(Deadpan)* ". . . and then I said 'Listen girl. You just a squirrel in my world.'

MOM: What was all that shouting out there?

EDNA: Nothing.

MOM: I don't want you getting mixed up with those people you understand me?

EDNA: I know.

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EDNA: **(pg 31)** My father came home one day with a present I thought was going to change my life! It was my very own record player! **(pg 37-38)** In honor of [the] new record player, I created The Record Player Night Club down in the basement. It was probably the best place ever invented. *(Edna runs a distance from the room and acts like she's entering for the first ime)* Ohhh! Oh! This place is incredible *(In a British accent)* This place is totally mod, luv! *(puts on a record and begins swaying to music that we can't hear)* **(Pg 40-41)** *(Pounding on the door – Bonna enters with her own records)* Bonna!

BONNA: Heard you got a record player . . . can I play it?

EDNA: I didn't know what I was supposed to do because we still had the rule of No Negro Kids Can Come In Our House. I didn't know how I was going to explain the rule to Bonna. Then I figured out we were in the basement so it would be OK with mom as long as [she] didn't come inside the real part of our house. *(Bonna puts on a record "I'm Black and I'm Proud" – she sings and dances along)* Bonna's records had a screaming sound that I had never heard before.

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BONNA: James Brown. (*sings)* Say it loud. I'm Black and I'm proud *(Bonna does a black power fist. Edna has no idea what it is and briefly does a lame and low version of it back)*

EDNA: **(Pg 42)** I had never heard of being proud about being a Negro before so I wondered, is this a joke song or what? She also told me that Blank Panthers were coming to beat the whitey's, and I didn't know what she was talking about. *(To Bonna)* I know that. Who doesn't know that? *(Bonna puts on a new record "The Tighten Up" and begins to move to the music)*

BONNA: *(To Edna)* Come on. I'm going to show you my cousin's dance called The Tighten Up

EDNA: I already know that dance.

BONNA: Prove it.

EDNA: Maybe I don't feel like it.

BONNA: You lie you die.

EDNA: Shut up.

BONNA: Come on. I just got it from my cousin in DC so I know no one here knows it yet. – Stand over here. *(Impossibly fast)* Go sideways like this and move your hand like this and your other one like this then when they go "Now make it mellow" move your arms like this.

MRS. WILLIS: *(off stage)* Where are you? Bonna! Bonna Willis!

BONNA: Gotta go *(she takes off)*

EDNA: That night I imagined me and Bonna becoming best friends. What that would be like and how everyone in the neighborhood would start to be afraid of me the same way they were afraid of her. *(Edna begins dancing the way Bonna had shown her)* I saw myself being able to do The Tighten Up so perfectly that people would faint from amazement. Me and Bonna in front of the lunchroom during assembly, doing the Tighten Up.

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(pg 65-66) *(Edna and Bonna on the porch – singing together to "Weak Spot")*

EDNA: Gotta go.

BONNA: No. Street lights not even on yet. Your mom says you don't have to go back 'til the street light comes on. Ask your mom can you stay over!

EDNA: Stay overnight?

BONNA: Yeah. My mom don't care.

EDNA: Bonna. Wait . . . Uh . . .

BONNA: What?

EDNA: You can probably stay over at my house.

BONNA: Why can't you stay over at mine? . . . . Because she doesn't like me.

EDNA: She dos so. She just acts that way because she . . . she . . she . . . gets headaches. Walk me!

BONNA: Forget you!

EDNA: Come on. I'm always walking you. Come on! *(To audience)* Everyday it was like that. I would get up every morning and go to her house of if she got up first she would come to mine and we would just spend the day together doing it didn't matter what. She was all I thought about. Every day I would say it in my head. "My Best Friend Bonna."

BONNA: Hey! My mom just called your mom and she said you could stay over. *(Edna looks at her astonished)* AAAAAAaaaahhh! Psyched you out! I got you! OOOOOooo psych on Edna!

EDNA: Every night she would walk me to my house . . .

BONNA: Then we would turn around . . .

EDNA: And I would walk her to hers . . .

BONNA: then we would turn around and . . .

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EDNA: I remember standing on my front porch watching her and waving goodbye until the last possible second. And I thought it was going to be like that forever. I thought we would grow up, get married to twins, and live next door to each other for the rest of our lives.

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EDNA: **(Pg 76-77)** In the middle of summer my aunt Margaret saw a TV special on racial prejudice. From then on for about two weeks, her new hobby was . . .

AUNT MARGARET: Improving the life of the underprivileged Negro. Everyone must do their part or the ones in our area are going to get as mad as the ones I saw on TV and burn everything we own right to the ground.

UNCLE DON: Well, everyone agrees it was a mistake to bring them here in the first place and they aren't happy, so why not send them back?

EDNA: Bonna, do you want to go back to Africa?

BONNA: Edna, sometimes you can be so stupid.

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EDNA: *(Singing Kumbiaya)* The song of all Girls Scouts was the first song I ever got sick of in my whole life. Ever since I first knew about Girl Scouts I had always wanted to be one. If I joined Girl Scouts I would get to hang around Joycie Mercer, our troop's most popular girl. She had a canopy bed. She was my dream.

BONNA: Joyie Mercer!

THERESA: Edna, Joycie Mercer says she wants to talk to you

BONNA: Don't she got legs? Can't she come over here and tell us her own self?

THERESA: Excuse me but I'm afraid I was talking to Edna. . . It's about her party.

BONNA: What Party?

THERESA: It's going to be a blast! *(She walks off)*

BONNA: *(to Edna)* What party?

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EDNA: Don't ask me. I don't know. *(Stares off in the direction of Joycie Mercer)*

BONNA: If you want to talk to her so bad, then just go.

EDNA: Bonna.

BONNA: I'm quitting Girl Scouts. I am. I hate it. I always hated it. I'm sick of [wearing] ugly uniforms and sell[ing] nasty cookies.

EDNA: If you hate it so much then why'd you even join?

BONNA: You asked me to, remember?

EDNA: Bonna! Will you quite being so weird? It's not like I can control who Joycie Merer invites in her life! *(Bonna leaves)* Bonna! For the rest of the summer it was like that. Whenever I saw her I got this feeling in my stomach of two magnets pointing the wrong way and I couldn't get them to point back right. *(They catch each other's eye and quickly turn away)*

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TOGETHER: SEVENTH GRADE:

BONNA: Every kid from my old school, all of us who had ever lived on the same street together and played together all our lives stopped talking and walking with each other.

EDNA: From second we walked through those school doors we all automatically split into groups of who was alike. Everyone knew exactly what to do. We had to constantly read books and poems about equality in English and I wondered sometimes if Bonna thought of me in the way I thought of her when I read them. To Kill a Mockingbird. A Raisin in the Sun.

BONNA: "What happens to a dream deferred?" Yeah. I thought of you.

EDNA: We had to write out own stories and poems and discuss them. We could each write [our own] answer and the answer was always the same.

BONNA: Love each other, love each other, love each other.

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EDNA: And we really through that things could change until the bell would ring, and we would go back into the hallway and know there is no way some puny little poem or story could change anything. *(A black girl walks up behind Edna and runs into her)*

KIMMY: Get your big behind out of my way.

EDNA: I'm not in your way.

KIMMY: What'd you just say to me? Girl, I'm talking to you. *(Edna turns to walk away and Kimmy shoves her. Bonna watches without saying anything)*

EDNA: *(To Bonna)* Why don't you tell them? Why don't you do something, stupid? *(Bonna squares off against Edna)* I couldn't believe she was really going to hit me because I knew that inside we were still friends. We are! *(Bonna slaps Edna hard)* Don't you even remember? I know your mother and father! I know the color of the walls in your room.

BONNA: The next thing I knew we were snatched by the arms and dragged down to the office just like I had seen girls being dragged every day since I got there.

EDNA: We sat in chairs waiting for the vice principal to come. I tried looking at Bonna but she kept staring straight ahead. I could see the streaks on her face.

BONNA: I heard Edna crying but I couldn't look at her. Seems like we sat there forever.

EDNA: We acted like we had never met. Like all it was any black girl slapping any white girl that mouthed off to her. Something that happened every single day and would just keep on happening would without end. When he called my mother to tell her, she never knew that the girl they were talking about was Bonna. Just like Bonna's father never knew that the other girl was me.

BONNA and EDNA: *(Sing Uncloudy Day)*

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AWARD HISTORY

2001 National Qualifier
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Music incorporated in this cutting:

- ***Uncloudy(ed) Day by Brenda Lee - https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=SAA6p389o4s***
- ***Sound of Music by Julie Andrews - https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=tsZzo2kKxI4***
- ***Say it Loud by I'm Black and I'm Proud - https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2VRSAVDlpDI***
- ***The Tighten Up by Archie Bell & the Drells - https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=uN7vm-k-AaA (Also includes dance moves)***
- ***Weak Spot by Evelyn Thomas - https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=NK0HPLZwLcM***
- ***Kumbiaya – an old folk song - https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=X_eWUOYiWVo***

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